

knot of worldly delusion. It all happened on the final oxen-cart ride home.

Addressing his father while standing tall on the moving cart, Dungar Bhakta imparted spiritual wisdom that was completely natural to him. "To believe you are my father and I am your son is a state of complete ignorance," he declared in his opening statement. Dungar Bhakta explained how the body is subject to destruction along with bodily affiliations.

He outlined the ultimate goal of human life: this body is a gift from God, but those who keep themselves attached to this world and their homes are stuck in a dark hole; the only successful end of the human frame is to apply intelligence to the task of searching for the true sadhu; one must stay in communion with the true sadhu; it is vital to shatter the sense of ownership one maintains for the perishable body; and it is necessary to practice devotion towards God.

Dhoribhai, with tears trickling down his cheeks, had his gaze fixed on Dungar Bhakta. His son's words had penetrated his heart. Despite having associated with senior sadhus of the Sampradaya countless times, no one proved as effective as his young son.

Dungar Bhakta's wisdom did not represent a mere arrangement of knowledge-filled words and sentences. It was not something learned over a fixed period of time. It was an inherently deep conviction that leapt out at a climactic moment.

Dhoribhai combatted his heartfelt emotions and permitted principle to finally govern his decision.

Dhoribhai ultimately succumbed to his son's strong inclination. Finally acknowledging that love towards family members is transitory and a cause for subsequent births, Dhoribhai was left with no choice but to allow Dungar Bhakta to relinquish secular life. ♦

THE VARTAL OF HIS CHILDHOOD

Sadhu Aksharatidas



Shastriji Maharaj departs from Vartal with five sadhus and about 150 devotees

Imagine. It is November 13, 1905. We are gathered at Shastriji Yagnapurushdas's *asan*

in Vartal. The leading devotees have just come back from the Acharya's room. "Who'd give him a letter to travel the villages? The whole country is lying open. He can go wherever he pleases!" The Acharya's response was far from what they had expected.

It seems the moment foretold by the events of the last few days is here at last. Only yesterday, when Krishnaji Ada finally convinced Shastri Yagnapurushdasji to part from Vartal, everyone had found such relief in the possibility of this instant. Yet now, no one is saying a thing.

Shastriji Maharaj is quiet as well. But his silence is different, untainted by turmoil. He simply sits still in the middle of an emotional storm, and one cannot help but try to follow his distant gaze and search for the thoughts that occupy his mind. It is then, in that moment, that



Dungar Bhagat collects and reads the discarded manuscripts of Bhaktachintamani and Vachanamrut

I feel brushed by the wind of a little boy running down the hallway.

His name was Dungar and he had always come to spend his time at the sadhus' residences. In this very hallway, he had met countless sadhus initiated by Bhagwan Swaminarayan himself. He would run from seat to seat bowing down to each of the great *sadgurus*. After meeting them all, he would go to Adbhutanand Swami. Here, he would serve Swami and then sit to listen as Adbhutanand Swami spoke on *vairagya* and the fickleness of this world.

As Dungar fades down the hallway, Shastri Yagnapurushdas finishes speaking to Purushottamdas Swami; he is going to have to stay behind in case the Acharya changes his mind. A few of the devotees depart to pass the word that the time has come – "Shastri is leaving Vartal." Swami stands up and in his footsteps follow Narayancharandas Swami, Niranjandas Swami and three other sadhus. They begin to pack their *potluses*. Swami is the lead sadhu of Vignananand Swami's group and heir to his seat and belongings in Vartal. Today, he searches inside Vignananand Swami's cabinet for the last time. As he gathers the few things that might be

called his, he probably doesn't see the boy that fills my eyes.

Dungar was at the cabinet 25 years ago. Vignananand Swami's arrival in Vartal had ended his search for a great *paramhansa* of Shriji Maharaj to make his guru. It was Swami who had first asked him, "Child, do you want to become a sadhu?" Dungar's heart had leapt with joy. He followed Swami to Surat, received *diksha* on Swami's recommendation, and began his studies of Sanskrit; it was Vignananand Swami who had loved him like a father, trusted him with the responsibilities of managing Surat mandir, and even supported his embrace of the Akshar-Purushottam *upasana* and Bhagatji Maharaj.

All of that had started right around this cabinet. And now Swamishri is closing it for the last time. He steps out of the sadhus' residences and into the grand quad of the mandir. I can only marvel at his steps – steady, purposeful, unashamed; his stride is so much like a lion's gait, except that his strength does not come from arrogant nonchalance but from the humility of accepting a greater will. Five brave sadhus quietly follow him. About a hundred or so of us trail behind them. Devotees and sadhus are looking on from the balconies above us. Sadhus speaking in the assembly hall abruptly stop; their eyes and the eyes of their audience are fixing on Yagnapurushdas. It seems that almost everyone has something to whisper to someone else, but what they think are quiet pronouncements are collectively becoming a hum echoing from the compound's structures. Some, who think themselves bold, jeer as Swami passes. Others, like Gordhandas Kothari, are brave enough to recognize Swamishri's integrity and saintliness. Mentally or physically, they fold their hands and bow their heads. Some even let tears flow. And amid them, amongst their humming, their jeers, and their sighs and sobs, I hear the laugh of Dungar.

Every *ekadashi* and *punam*, since the age

of seven, Dungar had come running into this compound, sometimes led by his brothers and father, but most times leading. How many times had he walked around the square searching for the discarded pages of the mandir scribes? Dungar could hardly keep count. But every time he found some pages, he would take them and sit down, reading them in the style of a pundit. This was also the square that used to echo with his laughter as he ran away from his family to meet the sadhus in their residences. It was amongst these very walls, that he had discovered the relics of Shriji Maharaj and had their darshan. It was here, in front of the *sabha mandap*, that he had boldly told Bechar Bhagat to become a sadhu from within. He had climbed the stairs of the Acharya's haveli so many times that the *parshads* and even the current Acharya's father called him by name.

But today is a different story. Swami does not climb the stairs to the haveli; he climbs the stairs across from them, to the mandir. He does darshan of all the *murtis* with great love. But in front of Harikrishna Maharaj he pauses more than anywhere else. This is the *murti* Maharaj has consecrated himself. It is one of the most sacred *murtis* of the Swaminarayan faith. Swami folds his hands, "Maharaj! We don't even remotely wish to separate, but if this is your wish then please always stay in our assistance; stay with us eternally." It was his last prayer to this *murti* – a *murti* he had spoken to since he was a boy.

What he prayed for no one could tell. Fear

was not a feeling Dungar had known. Worldly things did not entice him. But, nonetheless, Dungar had stood in front of this same *murti* countless times as a child. Dungar's puja, his meditation, even his mind's free moments all focused on this form.

Shastriji Maharaj turns away. He climbs down the same stairs. His puja, his saffron robes, one or two books – those few things one might call his – hang over his right shoulder in his *potlu*. A *pagh* covers his head. His face is calm. He neither frowns with grief nor smiles with any pretense. Before anyone truly realizes what has happened, 41-year-old Swamishri, five sadhus, and about 150 devotees walk out the main gate of Vartal mandir for the sake of Akshar and Purushottam.

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To truly transport oneself to that time is currently impossible. However, one thing seems certain. It is impossible to imagine that fateful day in 1905 without marvelling at the depth of Shastriji Maharaj's faith in Akshar and Purushottam, the strength of his conviction to live for his faith. One is left in awe at the mettle of his detachment from all things other than Maharaj and Swami because the Vartal he was leaving was not just the throbbing heart of the Swaminarayan Sampradaya; it was not just a seat of power and authority; it was not just a place of comfort and honour; it was also the Vartal that had filled his childhood, the place he had spent his happiest childhood moments in devotion. Today, among all those other Vartals, he was leaving the Vartal of his childhood. ♦

(contd. from p. 3)

Then, Swamishri took a small chisel and inserted it at the base of the *murti* and slightly lifted it off the ground. The sadhus and devotees were amazed and happy at the miracle. They then lifted the *murti* and installed it in the central shrine.

Finally, Swamishri performed the *murti-pratishtha* rituals. In this way, for the first time,

the *murtis* of Akshar-Purushottam Maharaj were consecrated in the central shrine. Everyone hailed the names of Akshar-Purushottam, and Swamishri for his historic role in establishing the principle of Akshar-Purushottam as propagated by Bhagwan Swaminarayan.

We pay our tributes to Shastriji Maharaj on his 146th birthday on 8 February 2011. ♦